politics as a systematic inquiry to understand the truth about politics so as to explain the relationship between the State and the individual. He described and classified different political systems. ***Aristotle*** and ***Plato*** made immense contributions to the origin and development of the discipline. ***Plato*** analyzed different political systems and ***Aristotle***, closely following the trails of his teacher ***Plato***, gave the analysis a historical perspective. They tried to understand the working of different forms of governments.

ACTIVITY

Collect information about Arthashastra and have a discussion in class on it.

Politics was a matter of discussion in the churches during the medieval period as political power remained with the church under the Holy Roman Empire. The works of philosophers such as ***St. Augustine*** ('The City of God') amalgamated the principles of political philosophy with those of religion. It must be noted here that for the Greek and medieval philosophers, politics was a knowledge centering on the city-state, which by and large had spiritual bond. It was more of a community than a state.

It was during the Italian Renaissance that ***Niccolo Machiavelli*** laid the foundations of modern political science through his emphasis on empirical observation and investigation of political structures and political behaviour from a secular perspective. Politics, in the words of ***Harold Lasswell***, an American Political Scientist, is 'Who gets What, When and How?' This definition is based on the assumption that all societies exhibit sharp diversities with people pursuing different interests and values and hence there requires a mechanism through which the conflicting interests are reconciled. Also, scarcity of resources is a feature of all modern societies and so politics would mean the mechanism through which goods and resources are distributed. For ***Karl Marx***, politics was all about class conflict and political power and to ***David Easton*** politics meant 'the authoritative allocation of values'.

Political scientists have explained politics through its basic concepts such as power, order and justice. Power is the ability to make and enforce rules and to influence the behaviour of the individuals. Power may or may not be legitimate. One needs to understand the difference between power and authority. Authority is the moral or legal right and is the ability to control. It implies legitimacy, where power is exercised through established institutions and people willingly accept it as proper and just. Power, on the other hand, may or may not be legitimate.

Politics is also concerned about order which denotes the structures, rules, rituals, procedures and practices that make up the political system. As the majority is ruled by the minority, there is always an apprehension of the fairness of the government mechanism. Therefore, the exercise of power should be based on the foundations of justice. Thus, power, order and justice are regarded the basic concepts in politics. Since the late 19th century, the study of politics as an academic discipline is commonly referred to as 'Political Science'.

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